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RESIDENTS OFFER PRAYERS FOR THE VICTIMS OF A SUICIDE BLAST IN NORTH-WEST PAKISTAN

THERE IS A STRONG FEAR THAT THE TALIBAN MAY USE THE EXISTING JIHADI INFRASTRUCTURE IN PAKISTAN TO MOUNT ATTACKS AGAINST INDIA.

that as many as an estimated 15 lakh people have been displaced, and this may be the biggest exodus of people in the region since the Partition. While India is concerned at the plight of the Sikh refugees, a bigger worry is that some of these refugee camps may become an easy recruiting ground for terror groups.

Safety of Pakistan's nukes: A US Congressional report says that Pakistan currently possesses around 60 nuclear weapons and has successfully flexed its nuclear muscle to blackmail the international community. For now the safety of Pakistan's nuclear weapons does not seem to be undermined by the forward march of the Pakistan Taliban. Besides, the international interlocutors have reassured India about the safety of Pakistan's nuclear weapons. "We have been assured that Pakistan's

nuclear weapons are secure and we have no reasons to doubt that", said Pierre Lellouche, French special envoy to Afghanistan and Pakistan. Sources say, US President Barack Obama had also indicated this to Manmohan when the two met in London last month. The assessment here too is that their safety is not undermined, but with the instability that scenario cannot be ruled out. Diplomatic sources say that the US has ensured the safety of Pakistan's nuclear arsenal by verifying the command and control measures put in place by Islamabad. But there are no cast iron guarantees.

US push to restart Indo-Pak talks: In return for action against the Taliban, Islamabad is already seeking some returns from the US, including increased civilian and military aid. However indications are already

there that India may come under strong US pressure to resume peace talks with Pakistan. The US may force India to reduce troops on the Indo-Pak border. Obama has invested a lot of political capital on the success of his Af-Pak strategy and he is also keen to reassure Pakistan that India will play ball on the Kashmir issue. In a deft move, Zardari has said that India is not a primary threat to Pakistan and has even offered a joint meeting of the intelligence chiefs of the two countries. All this seems a part of a well thought-out Pakistani strategy to convince the US, that while Pakistan is making all the peace overtures, India is being cussed. Besides there may be foot-dragging over the Mumbai attacks investigations, something the new government should watch out for.

India's options: The new government must lay out a consistent but well calibrated Pakistan policy which ensures that India's concerns on terrorism are addressed. While Zardari's Government is on a slippery ground, the assessment here is that he is surrounded by members of his exile club who largely occupy key posts. New Delhi must reach out to a cross-section of the Pakistani polity besides General Ashfaq Parvez Kayani who will continue to be a key player. For India, the strategy should be to ensure that it draws red lines on the terror issue upfront, before it resumes dialogue with Pakistan. Now that the world recognises Pakistan as the problem, concerted international pressure must be applied to ensure that Pakistan permanently dismantles its terror infrastructure. ■